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Ben Sidran

Ben Sidran has made a significant contribution to American culture as a pianist, vocalist, songwriter, radio broadcaster, author, and record producer. His astute observations on society have generated a distinctive "Ben Sidran" sound.

Ben was interviewed via Zoom on November 15, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Ben Sidran with me this morning, and 9:00 your time, so thanks for starting out — did you have your coffee I hope?

BS: No, I was going to get it and the next thing I knew the time ran over me and so I'm going to really freeform it here.

MR: Okay. Well that's my motto. I had to practice this little introduction I have for you, so here goes. There might be a question at the end. Ben Sidran is, or was, a radio and television presenter, author, jazz and rock keyboardist, record producer, composer, performer, label owner, teacher, music critic, interviewer, and I'm going to add sociologist and father of a musician.

BS: All good.

MR: Why so many things?

BS: Well because at heart I'm just a huge jazz fan. It's all I ever wanted to do was be involved in the music and these are all different aspects of how I got involved in the music. So to me it's all kind of the same thing. I mean playing piano is something I've done since I was six years old and it doesn't feel any different than doing an interview on the radio or whatever. All those things that we tend to think of as separate really aren't at all, they're just ways to go through the jazz life, which isn't an easy process as we all know, and so it actually made it simpler for me, not more complicated, to have more legs on the stool that was supporting me.

MR: I like that analogy of legs on a stool. I know, I think of Kenny Davern, the marvelous clarinet player. And he somehow made a living just being a clarinet player. Not — no studio work, he was in a big band for a very short time and he said no I'm not going to do that. And all the things that you've done — have they affected your questions that you asked during your interviews that you've done?

BS: That's funny, I think of it the other way around. All the interviews that I've done have really affected my playing in that the takeaway from so many of the people I've talked to

sound like somebody else you're doomed to be second best, they're already doing it. So at some point I really settled into owning my playing and not worrying about whether it was I don't know, authentically part of the tradition or — I stopped comparing my performance and the time I put in and my practicing — I stopped comparing it with my hopes and dreams from being a 13-year-old kid or whatever, and just accepted it, and that really came from conversations with all — I mean Miles Davis, Sonny Rollins, Art Blakey, anybody you talk to will tell you that. And that's the takeaway, you know like I said to I think it was Herbie Hancock or whatever, like what was the influence of being with Miles, and everybody said the same thing, be yourself. That was the whole takeaway. Not this note, that chord, this approach, just be yourself.

MR: Did you have a particular question, you sort of just answered it but it was specific to Miles, but I have a question that I usually ask about improvising, what are you thinking about when you're improvising. And I almost always get the same basic answer. I'm not going to say what it is, I mean I could, but I wonder if you've had questions like that, that you usually find the same answer?

BS: Well yeah. One of them is where does your sound come from. Where does your style come from. I asked everybody that. And nobody knew, nobody could answer the question. Miles came closest, he said, "Oh man, my sound, it's like your sweat." It's like your sweat. So I asked everybody where your sound comes from and where your style comes from. And it makes sense that nobody could answer that because you can't really see yourself or hear yourself the way other people do. As a matter of fact that's one of the really big takeaways from the recording experiences that I've had is that when you're playing live in the world, the sound goes away from you. Whether you're a trumpet player, a piano player, saxophone player — it's going that way. But when you're recording and you have earphones on, the sound is coming this way. And it's a very different perspective. You tend to say to yourself wait a minute, I don't sound like that. But of course that's exactly how you sound, you just haven't heard it.

MR: I have to say that reminds me of — I just had a flashback to when I was a kid and the first time I heard my own voice on a recording — "Oh, that can't be me."

BS: Yeah, yeah. Exactly.

MR: Was it intimidating at first, with that experience? Like this is really what I sound like 'cause it's coming back to my head, and I'm not sure I like it.

BS: Well the first time I had earphones on I didn't like it at all. I thought I sounded like my father, which was very problematic for me. I heard my father's voice in my own voice, and I had never heard that. But yeah, and it took years frankly, 'cause I'm not a natural vocalist. I, you know, sang and do sing, continue to sing, because it's a way to present

never put any time into learning to use my voice, and particularly with the microphone. You know these microphones today, you can really work with them to project a certain persona or image, they're so sensitive that you can't do in the real world. It's like working with a microphone. And that's this whole territory that opens up for you once you get into a studio.

MR: It reminds me of, I had a conversation with Dave Frishberg and he said, "When I write I'm writing according to the limitations of my own vocal ability." And then he said, "I bet Mose Allison would say the same thing. A lot of his songs are shaped by the way he sings."

BS: Yeah. I think that's true. I know Mose also believed that he had to be playing piano in order to sing, that they were of one piece. You had to be sitting at the piano and accompanying himself when he sang.

MR: Did that make it harder to — harder is not the right word — but often times, as you well know, vocals are overdubbed and you have more control over it so if he's playing the piano at the same time it's just another task for the engineer I guess.

BS: You know I was his producer for a while, I produced six records for him. And he didn't overdub anything. Everything was captured. Nothing was manufactured. But if you listen to his early recordings, you know he tends to make kind of grunting sounds when he's improvising, a lot of jazz musicians do. But on his first records the engineer could have muted his vocal mic during his solos but didn't. And he was treated harshly that way because the records would come out and you could hear him. And reviewers commented on it. So there is a responsibility from the engineer but generally speaking for Mose it was one thing, it really — he was not going to separate it out.

MR: You said in around 1990 during one of your presentations, you have a desire to demystify the world of jazz. Jazz musicians are just like the rest of us only more so. Can you expand on that a tad?

BS: Sure. I first fell in love with the music when I was like, well that's not fair 'cause when I was really little I liked boogie-woogie and that's pretty close to jazz. And just the drive and forward momentum of it felt so good when you're an 8-year-old kid man, I loved that. But when I was like 12 or 13 I heard a Horace Silver record. And it really just stunned me. I thought who are these people? Where are they? How can I find out what they're doing? What is this thing they're doing? Because you've got to remember back then this would have been in the '50s, they didn't really teach jazz anywhere. And if you wanted to learn it you had to get next to the people and be there. And so it was like learning a foreign language. It was free range. And so I became fascinated with the people who made the music as well as the music. And I found first of all there was so

difficult really, that I would say everybody that I ran into coming up was very accommodating. They weren't overly friendly necessarily, but they respected the effort that you had to put in to try to be a player. And I found also their sense of humor is what got them through the life and the music, it's kind of a foxhole sense of humor. And there are all these elements of being a jazz musician that were very typical of just being alive in the modern world, except they were heightened, they were focused up. The life of a jazz musician was such that all the kind of things that people tend to bury as they go through life were closer to the surface with these people, and they tended to be very philosophical — philosophical humor really stood out to me. So that's what I was thinking when I said they're like everybody else only more so because people at the time were putting jazz musicians at arm's length. You know? Oh well they're different, or oh that's a different kind of person. You have to be a certain kind of person to be involved in this nightclub scene or whatever. And basically if they didn't approach it that way they would put him on a pedestal academically. "Oh well he's a genius" you know. Oh that's a genius. He's not normal. And so my thought was in the service of the music it would be helpful to find a way to let people know that this music, as Johnny Griffin used to say, "is your music, it's my music, it's everybody's music." There's nothing that I hear that you don't hear, we all hear the same stuff. So that's kind of where I was coming from with that idea.

MR: You spoke about how their emotions were amplified closer to the surface, it reminded me I had a note to myself that forty years ago, during "Jazz Class," your presentation, you said, "Jazz is in trouble partly because of the long form and our increasingly short attention span." But also that it "brings out emotions that people tend to want to avoid."

BS: I said that, did I?

MR: You did. I have some quotes here. But if jazz was in trouble forty years ago, where is it now?

BS: Well you know there's a lot of discussion about that today. And it centers on the fact that we have so many people learning it in academic situations and what's the impact of that? I mean and that goes right to the question of style, where does style come from? You know almost everybody, when they get down to it, will say that style comes from how you recover from what you perceive to be as mistakes. They're not mistakes, they're opportunities. And it's in the recovery of playing something you didn't intend or whatever that your sound comes out and your style comes out. But if you learn the music as part of a syllabus, if you are in fact graded on the music, that's going to give you an entirely different relationship to the experience of playing music. So while today we have brilliant young players, I mean every instrument — piano players, saxophone players, they've never been better prepared to play this music and with the Internet everything's

something to do with being a sideman and learning out on the road and being on a bus with other musicians. It has something to do with the grit that was in the music that tends not to be in the music that way anymore because well it's often said, if you spend eight hours a day in a practice room, you're going to sound like you're in a practice room. If you spend eight hours a day hanging out with musicians and riding on the bus like they used to do, that's going to affect how you sound as well. So I wouldn't say jazz is in trouble, because there are more people playing it today than ever before. I would say that just as in all evolutionary processes eventually you start to get a different kind of animal. The jazz that's played by young people today for example tends to be highly calculated, like they like to play — kids today like to play with meter and rhythm instead of, you know 4/4 was disrupted after fifty years by 3/4 that took fifty years to play a waltz. Jazz musicians were not that interested in 15, 17 time signatures. But you know after the sixties and Coltrane and everybody there was only so much you could do to do something new. He had extended the harmony and extended the rhythm as far as you can, so you start playing with the forms. And the more you play with the forms, you know, well and people would say well I'm being myself, I'm extending my reach. But at the same time, it's not swinging. And that's a big issue today.

MR: I — in my limited listening to current releases, I'm sometimes mystified by the fact that it seems that nobody in the quartet or quintet wants to just — is not satisfied with just playing time. They all want to mess with it. And when there's no — for me — when there's no steady thing to be at the base of it I guess I just turn off.

BS: Yeah. Well as do I frankly. I consider swing and having some familiarity with the blues — whatever that means — is essential in jazz and always has been. And I think one of the reasons is very human and very physical. And I think there's a reason why 4/4 time or common time, or the people's time was the platform upon which this music was built. And it's because what swing is is a dotted eighth note, you know. It's bop-bop. Short long. Short long, Bop-bop. And so the shuffle rhythm is [scats] it's not dot-dot-dot-dot-dot, it's well that's your heartbeat [heart beats]. It's directly connected to our organic situation here. And when you start messing with swing, you're actually doing something much greater than being clever, you're pulling out a support of what makes the music have forward momentum. And so it relies more on how clever you are. And what jazz has really traditionally been about is supporting your colleagues. The four of us in a quartet have all — all have to be in this together. If there's one person up there who's not supporting everybody else and making it happen, it's not going to swing. Or it's not going to swing like it could. So I think that's what we're talking.

MR: Let me take you back for a bit. Why did you go to England to work on a Ph.D. in

BS: Well by that point I was really interested in the sociology of black music. We're talking about the late '60s. And nobody was talking about this. And people weren't talking about the importance of popular culture back then. Now it's everywhere of course. But back then popular culture would have been irrelevant in the academic world. Who cares or who even knows what it is? It was Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* that got me started thinking about how we perceive the world and how we move through it in terms of what we hear, what we see, what we do. It's not just a reflection of who we are but a cause of who we are. And I had all these thoughts in my head about the music and I was completely caught up in the culture of the '60s. And there was this interdisciplinary graduate program at Sussex University in Brighton. It was really ahead of its time. American Studies is really interdisciplinary approach using the various elements of history, sociology, psychology, literature, whatever you want, to study a larger picture. And I wanted to talk about black music in America and the politics of America and the sociology of living in America. And there were very few places where you could do that. One was Yale, which because also it was during the Vietnam War and I wasn't unhappy about leaving the United States at the time, so that's how I got to Sussex University.

MR: Did the British professors — well maybe you don't have a comparison for this, but I'm just wondering if their attitudes and philosophies about America would be significantly different than American professors?

BS: Absolutely. Absolutely. I was stunned actually my first semester there when I took a seminar the title of which had something to do with the American identity. And I didn't know Americans had an identity, I had no thought about an American identity. I mean I could give you a précis of the French identity or the British identity, but I always thought of America as just being chaos in a way. But the fact that they were talking about the American identity I found fascinating. And again, it partially was being able to see the forest when you got outside of the trees and I was able to look at America. I mean for example we were all consumed with the Vietnam was but when I got to England — it was shocking — discovered that it wasn't their war, they weren't talking about it. Yeah. And the courses that I took were very interesting and applicable to what I was concerned about. Like I had a sociology course and my takeaway from that course was to the other guy you are the other guy. And I thought that's, you know, we're all together in this. We're all outsiders in some sense.

MR: I wonder, I'm picturing a scenario that you write home to whomever and, "Yeah studies are going good and yeah, and I'm doing sessions with Eric Clapton and the Rolling Stones."

BS: I didn't write that. It was such a smaller scene back then. Like if you say the Rolling

trucks and planes and stuff. But back, this was 1967, 1968 — I mean they were well known, they had some hit records, but there was a scene — this one particular recording studio, it was called Olympic Studios, it was outside of London. I went to school in Brighton, which was a one hour train ride up to London. And while I was in graduate school friends of mine from San Francisco had come over to England, they had been signed to Capitol Records and they were going to make their first record in England. And so I would go up at night on the train and play on the sessions, hang out with the musicians. And in this studio, Olympic Studios, everybody was just hanging out. I got to know Charlie Watts pretty well, a big jazz fan. Eric Clapton showed up on a session I was doing with an American guitar player named Jesse Ed Davis. I mean people were just hanging out. And there was some advantage to being an American musician who had not just listened to the records but been there and seen it. I mean Peter Frampton and Eric Clapton were both completely obsessed with playing the blues. And when you came and you had spent some time in Chicago and yeah, I saw Muddy Waters or such people. It was very open that way. It wasn't, you know, very soon thereafter the record business took over the music industry and everything became frankly about money. But, there was that period, and particularly in England I think because the success that the British musicians had in the United States made a lot of musicians in the United States sit up and pay attention to our own music. There was a time when it was all available, and people were hanging out and I don't think we thought about it or I certainly didn't think about it as being unusual. It was only years later when somebody would say like, "Well you know what was Mick Jagger like?" Well he was a nice, polite guy. I mean he was just a guy. And the record business really separates musicians based on economics. So when Herbie Hancock for example got really famous back in the early '70s, one of the effects of that is it pulled him out of the pool. You weren't hanging out with Herbie Hancock anymore. Anyway, no I never wrote home about any of it, I just thought it was the way things were.

MR: How did they present the Stones or these other folks you worked with, how did they present the songs to you? Did they have a chord chart or they said here's how it goes, sit next to you with their guitars and you just learned it that way then played your part?

BS: Yeah. You didn't have a part, you made up your part. Yeah. It was the old aural tradition you know. You listened to the song, sometimes somebody would just play the song and play it over and over again until you found it, you know, until you found something that you could add to it or whatever. Very improvisational. Very rarely did you even see a chord chart.

MR: What's the first thing you went for when you were trying to learn this song just by hearing it? I'm picturing you at a keyboard like, I think I know the answer to this, you

BS: Yes.

MR: Yeah.

BS: Absolutely.

MR: Listen to the bass player?

BS: That's it. Listen to the bottom. Absolutely. What are we doing here? And then tried to get a sense of the shape. You know not everything is a twelve-bar blues you know. What's the shape? What's extended? What's the purpose of that movement — where the chord moves right there — what's the purpose. Is it to make it bigger? Is it to make it smaller? Is it a diversion and how can you amplify whatever the intention is. That's sort of how I look at it, not at all in terms of the notes or harmonics but just — recording is a lot like painting I think. You're really using colors and rhythm and stuff. And so when you first start out you think it's about energy and jamming. But it's not. It's not. Because what sounds big in the real world, like turn up the volume, when you put a microphone in front of the amplifier it actually sounds smaller on tape. If you want something to sound big you make it soft and you put the microphone right up next to it and coming out of the speakers it sounds huge. So you know recording is a whole other world, frankly.

MR: There's the Wurlitzer piano shows up in a number of your videos. Did they have Wurlitzer piano over there?

BS: Yeah. Yeah. They had everything. And the Wurlitzer was before the Fender Rhodes. It was the first electric keyboard. You know that's the one Ray Charles played on "What'd I Say" that just blew everybody's mind.

MR: And Joe Zawinul on "Mercy Mercy."

BS: Yes. Yes. And it was the first opportunity for a keyboard player to have a volume control. You know the guitar players had volume, but keyboard players had a microphone stuck in an upright piano. You know it wasn't fair competition. The Wurlitzer was great.

MR: Am I correct that you have a degree in English Literature?

BS: My undergraduate degree is English Literature. Yeah. And then my graduate degrees are in American Studies.

MR: I wonder if you can imagine when you were studying English Literature that you were going to be a lyricist who wrote — I'm looking for the correct adjective here — down home lyrics that tell an interesting story.

BS: It's all due to Mose Allison and Bob Dylan. Those two guys wrote in a way that I really respected. And I never wanted to be a clever writer. I wanted to be a kind of a Hoagy Carmichael sort of guy, or some piano player sitting in the corner kind of telling a story. That's part of the romance I think of what I thought of as the jazz life early on, being that character. So the — you create your persona. You create your character. I mean I'm

who I am that I want to communicate in order to tell a particular story. And the lyrics that I've come up with over the years and the songs all serve that, which is a lot like, I think, writing a short story where everything is trying to serve not just a punch line or a message but an environment. This is an environment. You know there doesn't have to be an answer to everything. We can sometimes just paint the picture and let the picture talk for itself. And so that's kind of how I approach lyric writing; not literally like story telling but embodying a point of view and letting that point of view tell the story.

MR: Do you have a title in mind before you start most of your songs?

BS: That's a good question. I often do. I often do. On the other hand a lot of times the title will emerge when some phrase becomes repetitive and you realize oh, well there's the title. Everything I write I have to say starts music first. I've never written something out that looks like a poem and then tried to put music to it. It always comes from sitting at the piano playing something. And Jon Hendricks, the great lyricist, told me that a lot of people think that what he does is fit words into a musical setting. He said, "Like a jeweler would put gems in a setting." He said, "But that's not it at all." He said, "The way I write words is I listen to the music over and over until the music starts talking. The music tells you the story."

MR: Oh that's terrific. I had the privilege of talking to him and he also said that sometimes he got — when he was doing "Sing a Song of Basie" he said he was watching his hand write out the words like he was getting this —

BS: Beautiful.

MR: Yeah.

BS: Yes.

MR: Let's talk about your music for a moment. We're going to play "continue this Bed Sidran lyric," okay? I'm going to read something and you see if you remember it. "They've been doing it in Brooklyn/Like it's going out of style/And all the cats in Cleveland/Got a great big smile."

BS: That's a relatively recent song. It's — gosh, boy in the last 15 years I've written so many songs.

MR: I'll give you a hint, it's something about St. Louis. "Don't Even Ask About St. Louis."

BS: You got me. What is it?

MR: I didn't mean to get you.

BS: What song is it?

MR: "Ahead by a mile/They've got that boom-boom-boom shaboogie."

BS: Oh it's "Boom Boom Shaboogie" of course. Of course. Well there's a classic example of something coming out of just a riff. Right. Well that was just being funny.

BS: Yeah. Well it's the heartbeat man.

MR: There you go. But there's something that caught me about that song because it starts out with this instrumental groove with a boogie, and the first singing that shows up sounds like it's on the bridge.

BS: Uh huh. It starts on the four chord. Yeah that's an old trick. That's a good old trick. It's you throw 'em a curve. So, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Well done.

BS: Thank you, thank you. Boy that's funny. I recognized the intent of the lyric I just couldn't place it. That's pretty obscure, Monk, I'm sorry but —

MR: Well it's like people like Bucky Pizzarelli for instance, you'll find a fact about him. For instance that he played on Ben E. King's "Stand By Me" and you'll tell him that and he'll go, "I did?"

BS: Yeah.

MR: So many sessions and you can't remember everything.

BS: Well and you know the songs that you remember most, obviously, are the ones that you tend to perform. A lot of times you know you'll write a song and then you'll record it, and for whatever reason it just doesn't slip into your set list and pretty soon you know you don't remember it anymore. I have my favorite hundred songs maybe that I wrote, but there are like three hundred of them, and there are a bunch of them that I couldn't tell you how they go anymore.

MR: How about this song "Too Many People, Nothing to Say." There's this fabulous rhythmic hook. I tried to write it down, I'm not sure I got it, it was like [scats].

BS: That's it. [Scats].

MR: Yeah. That little ghost note in there.

BS: Yeah, that's it. That's exactly right.

MR: How did the clarinets come to pass? Where does that come from? Do you have people who make suggestions? Is that all you?

BS: No. John Ellis, who played clarinet, I've been recording and playing gigs with him, I don't know maybe for ten years now. And he's got this real fresh open sound. And that was overdubbed, I mean we had that track and then you're absolutely right to say that whole track is built on that ghost note. And the lyrics — "Too many people/Got nothing to say/It's underhanded but I can understand it." It was just play. It was fun. And I gave a copy of that track to Ellis. Because he had worked — I mean it was kind of an R&B approach. And he came back with that really modern clarinet thing. I mean it was totally unexpected to me which actually gets to a point in how I approach recording, which is a lot of people know exactly what they want, and they'll tell you what they want, and

people. If I like somebody's approach and I like them as a player I'm open to what they come up with that is probably more interesting than what I'm looking for. Because what I'm looking for is just one — there's no right part really, to me. You know a lot of things could work. So often on the recordings that I've made I'll have something in mind and then somebody like Phil Woods will come along and just change the entire direction of what I imagined, and it's Phil Woods, well of course. You know that's why he's Phil Woods and that's why you hire him. And that's what that clarinet part was.

MR: Yeah and the bass clarinet doubling the bass parts, very cool.

BS: Very cool. Yeah.

MR: Later today if you went out to continue your day, what kind of things might you hear or see that could lead to a song title and a song?

BS: Well today, let's see — I'm trying to think the last few songs I wrote here where I am. That's funny — not funny — but this last year I turned 80 and I started writing some very dystopic songs. I mean I've always — you know people accused Mose Allison of being cynical. And he would say, "I'm not cynical I'm just telling it like it is." And I would always have to kind of half apologize after singing one of my songs like "I may be wrong but it sure seems to me the past ain't what it was and the future ain't what it used to be." So I just fell down this dystopic hole and why did I do that? You know I don't even watch the news anymore and I think that's part of it you know. The world has become such a deranged, inhuman place that everywhere you turn you have to confront humanity in a much larger frame than you would back in the day before there was such an onslaught of media where you could still talk about a boy and a girl holding hands and going on a date and that would be relevant. But now you can't — how could you write a song like that? You know if I go out my door at some point I'm going to see some homeless people. If I go out my door I'm going to hear some really cheesy popular music that is everywhere. I mean it makes me think a lot about the past. I makes me feel older. And so I guess I'm saying if I go out and have an experience I come back there'd probably be something nostalgic in the song I wrote that would probably be something, I don't know, I'm getting closer to Leonard Cohen every day.

MR: Good analogy. So I'm sitting here thinking how to respond to what you just said and I wonder if in all the interviewing that you've done, have you ever had a similar situation, who was interviewing someone who is approaching 80 and looking at the world at that time and suggesting a similar attitude. What would you have said to them?

BS: Huh. Well I think about a conversation I had with Gil Evans right at the end of his life, or a conversation I had with Pepper Adams actually is more to the point, also at the end of his life. Pepper was particularly upset about a critical review that John Wilson had

it was pretty harsh and it really kind of ended Pepper's opportunity to work with Monk, and he was just downcast thirty years later. The thing with Gil Evans is I don't know how it came up but what he said in talking about his career, he said, "All I ever wanted was my certified fair share, CFS." Certified Fair Share. And he said, "I don't think I ever got it." I think he's talking about in terms of credit and in terms of commercial success. And he was really down in the dumps about that too. I don't know if there is anything I could have said to either one of them other than just hear that it's more and more difficult to maintain that foxhole humor as you get older. And you know it's the physical challenges of playing the gig become more difficult than playing the gig. Johnny Griffin at the end, I was with him in France and he said he wasn't playing gigs anymore. And he was vibrant. We were having lunch and I said, "Why don't you play gigs anymore?" And he said, "I can't carry my horn. I can't physically walk through an airport and carry my horn." Oh my God, right? People don't think about how much of this music is physical and a reflection of the 22 hours of the day where you're not performing. You know the two hours that you get to be on stage with friends is wonderful, but the other 22 hours is brutal.

MR: Yes. Phil Woods said that. He said the stage is the sacred place. It's everything else that people don't know about.

BS: Yeah.

MR: People — the phrase "in the moment" shows up a lot. I think you've said it, playing jazz in the moment. And I've thought about it and I wonder if you think that there's so much going on when you're improvising because you're in the moment but you're also remembering or trying to remember what you just played, shall I play it again, how many choruses do I have, like wow, the brain must be very hyper intensive during improvisation.

BS: Well I don't think we're aware of how fast our mind works. It's really, really fast. Like when you have a thought and then you have another thought and then you have another thought. They could be all over the place but they just pop up, pop up, pop up. And it's like that when you play and it's really, you'll hear the expression you have to "get out of your own way." But that's a good description of what it means to be in the moment, to get out of your own way, to — if you're going to be in the flow of time, if you're going to be in the stream, then you don't, even though you have to be aware of the context of where you are and what you're playing, whether it's chord changes, whatever, whether it's physically where you are on the stage. Even though you are aware of all that you can't really be judging it. You don't have time to — well as I said before — it's how you recover from what you perceive as a mistake. If you dwell on something and you know,

Hendricks said, he watched his hand write the lyrics, you watch yourself play the solo. You hear yourself in the real time that everybody else hears you. And the extent to which you can do that, just listen to what you're playing rather than judge what you're playing or try to play something, you'll be in the moment. And it'll feel better even though, as I said before, you can't hear yourself while you're doing something. You're not a good judge of what you sound like ever. The process still has a very physical quality to it so that you know when you're getting out of your own way. You know when you're not stopping the flow of time. I have a funny expression which is people don't move through time, time moves through people. Time is not something that's just consistent and out there and we're walking around and everybody experiences the same time. Time is a function of how we feel. And we feel very differently every moment. So when we're playing, when we're improvising, particularly this would apply to a fast tempo. The way to play a fast tempo is to let go. If you try to hang on real tight you can't play that. But if you let go you can just flow with the tempo. So there's something in there about what it means to be in the moment. It's hard to talk about it.

MR: It is and something you said just made me think of the number of times I've read about, usually a saxophone player — someone transcribes their uptempo solo, they give it to them and, "I can't play that."

BS: Yup. Yup. I've seen transcriptions of something I've played and it doesn't seem familiar to me. It doesn't sound like something I would have played, or it doesn't look — that's the difference — it doesn't look like something I would have played.

MR: Explain a little more. Why doesn't it look like it?

BS: Well because when it's written out it becomes, it's a symbolic approach to something that was just a gesture. I mean like you and I are talking right now, but if we saw a transcription of what we're saying, which we might well one day see, it would exist, it wouldn't have the qualities or the character of what we're experiencing here. And I'd probably look at it, you might look at it and go, "Oh jeez, that was stupid, why did I say that?" You know? It's the same thing.

MR: Have you ever had someone not only transcribe your solo but try to explain it? I'm thinking of some of these solos that — I sometimes think some of these Ph.D. candidates have to do some publishing and they'll take a solo and there'll be a phrase where they just have to find a way to justify a note.

BS: Oh yes. Yeah.

MR: It simply could have been an unintended note but damn it we're going to figure out a way to call it something.

BS: Well that's again, the thought that there's a syllabus and an answer and an exam where

it's just one big pool of possibility. And you know the interesting thing is there are so many ways to learn how to improvise, there really are. I mean you can learn it from the feet up or the head down. You can learn to do it through the harmonics. You can do it through the melody. You can do it through modes. You can do it — there's so many ways to learn how to improvise. It makes you realize that these are all symbol systems. These are all grammars. There's the harmonic grammar. There's a melodic grammar. Whatever appeals to you, depending on your nature, is probably how you'll approach it. And it's a very personal experience and there's no right fit for everybody, but basically it's a conversation. And the grammar that you use determines what you get to say just like there are some things you can't say in English but you can say five different ways in Spanish. Or you know the grammar that you use is part of the box you're in and you're trying to get out of. You're trying to push the boundaries. And as we all know there's no freedom without boundaries, because there's no definition of freedom without the lack of freedom. So I think the — I'm totally confused.

MR: All right. I was just going to say, when we — we will be transcribing this and you're very quotable, Ben.

BS: Oh thank you.

MR: You have some gems in there. I'm wondering going back, were your parents happy with your career choice and were you, are you pleased that you son has gone into music?

BS: Well I was told growing up not to think of music as a career path. It was — my parents were happy that I play piano I guess, you know they didn't pay any attention to us back then. That's the bottom line. I mean kids were really free range 60, 70 years ago. But they were happy I play piano I guess, they were proud of me but it was never thought of as something serious to do. My father died when I was 24 years old I guess, 25. So he never saw what the career path turned into. My mother was thrilled that I became known, that people would know her son's name. That was really thrilling to her. But you know I think the reason that I went and got a Ph.D. was because I was really trying to please my father who obviously sent me the message that music was fine, music was fun, but life was serious. And I had, you know when I passed the oral exam and, you know there's this moment where somebody says, "Congratulations Doctor Sidran" my feeling was one of great letdown. I felt that's it? I thought something would change. I thought there would be some bigger payoff to all that work. That's it, huh? But the real story of why we're sitting here talking today is it had nothing to do with my intention. It had everything to do with riding the horse in the direction it's going. Because when I got my Ph.D. I sent out thirty letters of application to different schools around the country to get a teaching job. I still thought, even after playing with The Rolling Stones and Eric Clapton, even after

musician, right? Why me? I mean how can I be a piano player when McCoy Tyner is a piano player? How can I be a songwriter when Jon Hendricks is a songwriter? You know? I just didn't think there was a way to get there. And I got nothing back. There was no future for me in academics at that time. So I literally said well okay, I'm going to L.A. and I'm going to get in the record business. And that's what happened. I rode the horse in the direction it was going, and now we're here talking.

MR: I'm glad you got on that horse.

BS: Oh me too, oh me too. I can't tell you. I can't tell you. What a lucky thing. And I remember also you know when I was writing my dissertation and you know I was, there was information all around and I was trying to, you know, synthesize — I was trying to bring this information and try to figure out what I wanted to say and all that sort of thing. And one of the things that I definitely said to myself when I graduated was I don't want to study the information anymore. I want to become the information. I want to be the information. I want to know what it feels like to get paid at the end of a night, sitting there waiting for the club owner. I want to know — now I was naïve, because not all of what you learn is a lot of fun. But I did get to do that. I did get to learn what it felt like to be a musician and I guess really in the end that was my heart's deepest desire.

MR: And you got to see Blue Mitchell doing a hip little dance as he listened to a playback.

BS: Oh my God, I love Blue Mitchell. And so my son, God bless him, he would never let me show him anything, tell him anything about music or anything. And I did not encourage him. But I love hanging out with him. He's just a great guy. And so his whole life was spent on the road or in recording studios, and I couldn't show him piano but he'd go up to Mac Rebennack and Mac would show him something and he'd carry on with other musicians. But never with me. He would never interact with me until later when he got to be like 16 years old. And ironically this was in 1992 I guess. And I was doing a lot of producing. I had produced Mose, I had produced Van Morrison's record, there was a Diana Ross thing. I was really doing a lot of work. And I wasn't doing a lot of performing. And I was thinking well maybe I'm done with performing. Maybe it's enough. And just at that point when he was 16 he said, "Come on let's go play gigs, man, come on, you and me, let's go play." And because of his enthusiasm I started booking more gigs. And he got me back out there and it was so funny because for all those years he wouldn't interact with me at all, and then suddenly he totally turned me around and put me back on the road. So I'm eternally grateful that he did that because I've had more fun in the last 25 years than in the first 55. Yeah.

MR: It's harder to do the math the farther we go, doesn't it?

BS: Yes. Bigger numbers.

MR: Do you have a definition of your own producing? I've been able to ask this question to Orrin Keepnews and a few other people because it's not exactly a definable occupation.

BS: Right. Right. There's as many different ways to produce a record as there are to paint a picture or whatever. I mean I'm — the way I produce actually is not so much production as support. You know if I'm in there with Mose Allison, Mose knows who Mose Allison is. My job is to get the obstacles out of his way and make it possible for him to do what he's trying to do. And in the instance like that, that could be everything from taking care of all the mechanics of booking the sessions and the musicians, I mean it also includes sitting there talking about the songs, talking about who would be great to play on this or play on that. But I'm there to facilitate Mose's vision. That's how I look at that. Other productions, especially in the world of popular music, they have to be by definition a little more hands-on. And it's not so much facilitating as translating the image — because pop music is so much about image — translating the image that somebody brings to the music. And a lot of that is kind of giving the artist the confidence not to feel they have to fill up all the spaces. Just to leave a little sense of risk taking. Because when you're in there in a commercial situation everybody wants to control everything. Nobody wants to be exposed, right? So I feel like if you can leave a little spit coming out of the horn that's good for the listener. The listener gets to feel like oh it's a real person. So that's kind of how I approach it. There's no real magic, it's being in a room with a bunch of people and while you're in that room trying to make that room the best place to be, make it enjoyable, make it profound, make it seem like nothing's going on but we're ordering lunch. You know never give the impression that anything is critical.

MR: Yeah, speaking of critical, have you been in a situation where you really felt you had to tell the supporting musicians that for instance they're overplaying, let's keep it basic? I guess I'm thinking of bass players and drummers especially.

BS: Well yes and no. I mean I was very lucky, I got to play with Blue Mitchell. I got to play with great musicians. And even, I mean I cut some tracks at one point with Richard Davis and Tony Williams. We did it as a trio. And I was at one point talking to Tony about what I was hearing. And in the back of my head it's you can't tell Tony Williams, who do you think you are? But it's defused when you're talking about the music. So it's not a problem. But I have had the experience for example of working with, see as you can tell I have a real distinction between rock & roll, commercial music, and jazz. I think they shouldn't even be in the same sentence. Because most rock & roll music is theater. It's a lie. Quite frankly it's a lie. The Rolling Stones for example are not "street fighting men," but that was the presentation, right? Rock & roll is a lie. It's theater, but anyway, jazz is a truth. It's the deepest truth I think. And I came along at a time when you had to

late ‘60s, early ‘70s, jazz was dead in the water. There were no gigs, there was nothing going on. So you either got involved in pop music or you didn’t, you didn’t work a lot. And I was working as a producer at one point for the CBS Columbia Records arm in England. And they assigned this band to me as a producer, and go produce this band. And after four weeks I went back to the company and say I quit. I said I quit. There’s not a record in these people. You know we’re sitting here in this room and they want me to write their song for them. Well some producers are happy to do that. That’s not who I am, I’m not going to write your song. I’m going to try my best to capture your song but I’m not going to manufacture your song. And the person I said it to said to me, “Ben, don’t do that. Don’t. Finish. Get a record out of here one way or the other, that’s what a producer does.” And so the road forked for me there. I realized well I’m not that, whatever that is, I can’t do that. I don’t know how to live with myself and do that. It’s like I’m making sausage at that point and I don’t know how to make sausage in a recording studio.

MR: Were the members of that band — didn’t deserve to be there really?

BS: One of them had talent, the other three did not deserve to be there. They got signed — you know back then the record companies really had no idea what to do and so they were just throwing money at young people who came through the door with a lot of attitude. And maybe there’d be a kid with a good voice, and maybe they had one song that was kind of catchy. And okay you’ve got a record deal. So it got sorted out of course. As soon as the real money showed up. When the real money showed up the real businessmen showed up, and then it wasn’t a free-for-all anymore. By the mid ‘70s on the one hand you had disco and on the other hand you had heavy metal and on the — you know once it got divided into categories we can sell then we had a business. But up until then it was the wild west.

MR: This has been a most fascinating conversation. And of course I didn’t get to everything but I want to end with — well maybe this is a philosophical question. My musical hero is Cannonball Adderley and he said on record, “Hipness is not a state of mind, it’s a fact of life.”

BS: Yes he did.

MR: And Tower of Power said, “Hipness is what it is, sometimes it’s what it ain’t.” So Mr. Sidran, can you tell me what is hip?

BS: Tell me, tell me. I love what Cannonball said. I really, I remember the record. And I remember hearing it the first time and saying this man is a teacher boy. What is hip. Yeah you know so don’t cry for no hipster, he knew what he signed up for. The look in the field, the rundown appeal, the passing ship the distant shore. Don’t cry for no hipster, he saw the writing on the wall and it gave him hope, just another slippery slope, a deeper

we'll see if the truth can set him free. Until then don't cry for no hipster. He had his day and he had his night. And, I've got to conflate the ending — let's call it what it is, in a world like his it's usually the wrongs that make it right. That's as close as I could come.

MR: That is like right on target. More than I had hoped for.

BS: A lyric always does that. This is what a lyric can do.

MR: How old is that lyric?

BS: Fifteen years. Something like that.

MR: Okay. Keep it up.

BS: Yeah. Thank you. Well I am just finishing up a recording. You know every time I make a record I assume it's the last record I'll ever make. I never think that this is just a piece of a process. And so this new record, as I said, it's kind of dystopic because that's what I felt like last year. And there's a song called "Are We There Yet." And the lyrics are: "It came so softly that nobody heard it/The next thing you notice the streets were deserted/Lights were flashing, sirens were wailing/People were calling out but the systems were failing. What did it feel like? I can't remember. I think it was a Tuesday deep in December. Are we there yet? Are we there?" That was my way of capturing what the last couple of years have felt like. And there was no way to control that. When that song got written it kind of told me where it was going and I had to follow along. So when you say keep at it, all I have to do is just keep walking around the world. It's not voluntary. It's happening to me too. I guess that's the point.

MR: Are you tending more toward minor keys?

BS: Yes. Yes absolutely. But primarily because they're fun to play. You know minor keys, it's the whole 2-5-1 thing, right? You know why go 5 major to 1 major when you can go to 2 minor to 5? I mean it's that 2 minor that's more fun than anything.

MR: You know what? You know who said that?

BS: Who?

MR: Dave Frishberg.

BS: Really?

MR: Yes he did and he said, I had it here somewhere. He was talking about the 2-5 is the secret of the universe or something like that.

BS: Yeah, yeah I get it. Because you know if you hang out in that harmonic space it's like everything's a kind of roller coaster. It's fun. You're always on the way there, you never have to get there. You're always in the process, it's great.

MR: When are we going to get there? Not soon.

BS: Not soon. Hopefully not too soon, yeah. Hey thanks Monk, it's been a pleasure, really.

MR: Likewise, thank you very much. I'll just pause this and we'll have our good-byes. So we're back for a little addendum. And the question was the fact that I often ask what's the worst gig you ever played and I guess you had one?

BS: Yes. The worst gig I ever played was as the opening act for Rodney Dangerfield. It was at a theater in Tucson, Arizona. And Rodney of course, being a Las Vegas comic, often worked with jazz musicians. And so the promoter thought oh this will be great — you know Ben's kind of a hipster and Rodney is a hipster and we'll put them together and it's great. Well Rodney had just done this movie "Caddyshack" and been on the cover of *Rolling Stone*. So in the time between when the gig was booked and the gig actually happened Rodney had blown up into this caricature of himself and there were 2,000 kids in this theater who had memorized Rodney's latest record and were prepared to throw the punch lines back at him. It was a circus, it wasn't a gig. So I opened — oh and we're doing two shows. Two shows. And all I've got to do is 20 minutes. I opened for him. But here's the catch: the catch is Rodney has musicians in his act. He likes to work with a piano player and stuff, and he gives them different names. I say this because I know that I'm going to go play my opening set as Ben Sidran but then I'm going to come back out on stage as the piano player "Styles Bitchley" that's the name he gave me, and play behind him. Okay. Okay. It's Vegas — this could be cool. So we're waiting on the gig, Rodney shows up late, he comes in on a private little plane. He's got two hookers with him. He comes in to back stage and the next thing you know he's padding around in a bathrobe and slippers. And you hear from the dressing room one of the women saying, "Rodney, Rodney, you promised —" it was just oh my God. So okay, I go on stage, do my 20 minutes, no problem except I played two chords and from the back of the theater you could hear this thing starting, "Rodney Rodney Rodney" and they start chanting his name. And it's like I'm playing this little acoustic piano into a windstorm, it's like this storm is coming at me. I can't hear myself. And "Rodney Rodney." So I start trying to play harder and I look down, there's blood on the keys. You know "Rodney Rodney." I look over into the wings and there's the promoter going, "Sorry kid, you've got to do 20." So I had to sit up there for 20 minutes, go off stage, and come back as Styles Bitchley. That was the worst gig I ever played.

MR: May it never happen again.

BS: Yeah.

MR: Well thank you. Once again I got more than I asked for.

BS: You sure did.

MR: Okay.